

Sponsor: Blake Gideon
Steering committee: N/A

Problem Statement

Cell phone use by students in schools is a topic of controversy. The trend of using smartphones more and more in the classroom has been ongoing for the past 25 years. However, since the creation of the iPhone in 2007, the level of interference caused by phones has reached a disheartening level. For example, the use of apps like TikTok raises questions about addiction and mental health consequences. The impact of phones is tremendous, and anyone who has experienced the immersion of students and teachers in phones in the classroom is familiar with this. The ease of phone access at the school is most disheartening, and it seems like we are playing whack-a-mole.

In my institution, which prides itself on excellence, it is hard to see how phones in school could be anything but a hindrance to achieving institutional goals. They also undermine the social-emotional learning and mental health care in which schools play a more significant role. Some teachers would like to see cell phones prohibited in schools, while others believe students should develop executive functioning skills to manage their phone use. Administrators must monitor their institution's cell phone policy and ensure it aligns with the latest educational research.

In scope: The following issues fall within this project's scope: educational impact on students, mental health impact on students, and analysis of schools' technology policy.

Out of scope: This policy review will only inform on different policies at other schools and current best practices nationwide. It will not advocate or seek methods and mechanisms of change at Latin.

Cross-functional dependencies to be considered: Administrators, Faculty & Staff

Current Condition

Data Needed:

- Tech policies from handbooks at different schools
- Academic research reports
- Information from prominent individuals on this issue
- Information from current administrators about how they see the issue

Collection Methodology: I plan to collect data by requesting a copy of policies and conducting brief interviews with comparable schools about their technology policy.

Future state

Objective statement:

The future state of this project includes creating a PowerPoint presentation, which is expected to be delivered within 5-7 minutes, keeping in mind that people have a short attention span. Additionally, I plan to create a website to share and present my research concisely and well-referenced. The target audience for the presentation will be teachers, and if there is interest, potentially some administrators as well.

Implementation Plan Timeline

Feb '24 - Jun '24

- Obtain three tech policies from other schools
- Interview 3 admins outside of Latin
- Interview 1 Latin Admin

June '24 - August '24

- Read Anxious Generation by Haidt (or another book)
- Find, read, and analyze two academic articles relating to this issue

August '24 and Beyond

- Create a PowerPoint/website